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Created to Bear Fruit for God

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Created to Bear Fruit for God

Today's Reading: John 15:1-11

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"I am the true vine, and my Father is the vinedresser. Every branch in me that does not bear fruit he takes away, and every branch that does bear fruit he prunes that it may bear more fruit...I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing."

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This is the last of Jesus' seven "I am" statements in John's Gospel. Once again, it points to his deity.

He said, "I am the true vine." The word "true" contrasts him with Israel. The term "vine," or "vineyard," was used in Old Testament nomenclature as a symbol of Israel. But Israel failed to produce fruit for the Father and be a light to the nations.

That is why Jesus is the true vine. As his followers abide in him, they will succeed where Israel failed. Through them, the gospel will spread throughout the world.

The Father in heaven is the vinedresser. His work in you ensures fruitfulness. This happens when he connects you, the branches, with Jesus, the vine. What connects you is your faith. That's why the Lord desires great faith. When you are solidly one with him, his life will easily flow to you. Who he is becomes who you are. And with him, you can do anything.

As the vinedresser, the Father sometimes must prune branches. It can be painful, but it's very purposeful. He does this so you will bear more fruit.

The Father prunes you. He sees certain things in your life that are preventing full fruitfulness and must be removed. Thus, the painful process of pruning begins.

Perhaps you are experiencing that right now. Something in your life has been removed that you thought was important. You're wondering what the Father is doing.

As this pruning takes place, try to look at it from the Father's perspective. He knows you well. He realizes what is keeping your full growth in him from happening. Trust him in the pruning. Though it's painful, remember that he is an expert vinedresser. He knows what he's doing.

And remain solidly connected to Jesus. Then the fruit of the Spirit will be produced in your character: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Then who you are will be reproduced in the lives of others. Remember: You reproduce who you are and not what you do. This brings much glory and praise to God.

The Lord created you to bear great fruit for him—both inwardly and outwardly. You should be like a tree on a riverbank, bearing fruit each season for him. Even in old age, you are to remain vital for the Lord and produce fruit for his glory. That's why you were placed on this planet: For his life to be in you and to flow through you so that you bear much fruit for him.

Don't be dismayed when pruning takes place. The Father is removing some good and bad fruit so you can produce more and better fruit. Just make sure you remain connected to the vine.

You were created to bear great fruit for God.

Jesus is the true vine. Remain in him.

Apart from him, you can do nothing.

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]